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Lions writer awards: man of the series, unsung hero and where tourists should go next

Robert Kitson

Man of series Finn Russell was at the heart of everything the Lions did well. Calm, assured, skilful and accurate from the tee. Chapeau.

Try of series Tom Wright, second Test, Melbourne. What a ripper! Joseph-Aukuso Suaalii's midfield break split the Lions wide open and Wright's touchdown put his side 23-5 up.

Biggest villain Has to be Australia's now-convicted "mushroom murderer" Erin Patterson. Her shocking court case pushed the Lions way down the news agenda.

Unsung hero Jac Morgan. The brave back-rower never started a Test but Wales's solitary representative did himself – and his country – proud.

Favourite moment Everything about [the second Test](#) was brilliant. The stroll down to the iconic MCG, the pre-match vibe – excellent use of AC/DC's Hells Bells as intro music – followed by a belting game in front of 90,000 fans. This year's cricket Ashes will be fun.

Worst moment Idly looking around for my laptop bag only to realise – agh! – I'd left it in a Sydney taxi which was now 25km away. Fortunately, there was a happy ending.

This Lions tour was ... A reminder that sport is nothing without an audience. The previous Lions tour in South Africa took place behind closed doors; this one was enhanced by up to 40,000 visiting supporters, many of whom have been saving up to make the trip for years. All hail the sea of red.

Next stop for Lions should be ... To sit down and reimagine what future Lions tours should look like. Australia in 2037 including games in Japan and Fiji? France? South America? Or maybe an oval-ball Ryder Cup equivalent: Europe v the Rest of the World? Before somebody else launches it instead.

Gerard Meagher

Man of series Will Skelton, Australia. The cumulative scoreboard reflects that with the 23rd second row on the field, the Wallabies comfortably outscored the Lions. The overarching feeling at [full-time in Sydney](#) was just what might have happened had he been fit in Brisbane.

Try of series Tomos Williams for Lions v Western Force. Williams's second try of the match was a peach. Mack Hansen made the initial break, offloading inside to James Lowe, who found Williams dashing down the wing. The scrum-half exchanged passes with Lowe again before diving in the corner. Such a shame he injured his hamstring in doing so.

Biggest villain Not one individual but the TMO – a role occupied by various officials throughout – did not have a great tour. In Sydney on Saturday, Dan Sheehan's blatant illegal clearout on Tom Lynagh went unpunished before a second-half check for the most innocuous of occurrences.

Unsung hero Charlie Gamble, Waratahs and First Nations & Pasifika XV. Maybe not unsung given he was named player of the match [for the FNP side](#) and was praised for his performance for the Waratahs, but the beauty of tours such as this is watching players such as Gamble rewarded with an unlikely appearance in the series. Alas it didn't happen.

Favourite moment Owen Farrell giving his boots to a child who had run on to the pitch in Sydney, only to be led away by security. These are the sorts of gestures made by Farrell that tend to go unnoticed by those who love to slate the only member of this squad with two series wins to his name.

Worst moment Sweet Caroline, or something similarly obnoxious, blaring out while players are receiving treatment for worrying looking injuries. It has happened far too often, most recently when James Ryan was knocked cold for a couple of minutes in Sydney. Tone deaf.

This Lions tour was ... A slow burner and suddenly over too quickly, leaving a lingering sense of frustration that the Wallabies started the Test series so tamely. It did reach a stunning peak at the MCG and it should also be said it is always a stunning country to travel.

Next stop for Lions should be ... The couch or beach. It is August, the new football season is almost upon us and most of these players – some clearly running on fumes in Sydney – have been going non-stop since last September. There are mandated rest periods at the start of next season and the hope is that they are stuck to.

Jack Snape

Man of series Will Skelton. The return of the Wallabies' lock flipped the series' momentum and he starred again in the third Test.

Try of series Tom Wright, second Test. Joseph-Aukuso Suaalii lacerated the Lions' midfield with his left foot and when Wright crossed, for a moment, Australia believed.

Biggest villain Dan Sheehan. Tom Curry tackling a mid-air Tom Lynagh was egregious but Dan Sheehan's elbow to Lynagh's head was downright ugly.

Unsung hero Ellis Genge. The prop was unlucky to be benched after a dominant first Test but helped to turn the second match in Melbourne to secure the series.

Favourite moment The sheer drama of the final minute of the second Test, in front of 90,000, won't quickly be forgotten. The controversy made the Wallabies relevant to Australians again.

Worst moment The Wallabies were flying at the MCG but Tom Lynagh's fumble and Joseph-Aukuso Suaalii's infringement both led to tries that handed the Lions the impetus and ultimately the series.

This Lions tour was ... A reset for Wallabies fans, who can now look to the home 2027 World Cup with optimism. Wait, here come the Springboks, Pumas and All Blacks again.

Next stop for Lions should be ... To book a Lions Women tour to Australia in 2031.

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